

Unit 5 teacher notes

The thing to get right in this unit

This unit describes conditions that are genuinely difficult and, in several respects, not the trainee's fault. Taught badly it produces either despair or cynicism, and cynicism in a pre-service cohort is expensive: it arrives before they have taught anything, and it is the burnout dimension Topic 5.1 warns about, acquired second-hand.

Two things prevent that.

Reach Topic 5.4. Do not let the block run out with the difficulties described and the response untaught. If you are short of time, compress Topic 5.2, not 5.4. A unit that stops after three topics is worse than not teaching the unit at all.

Do not soften the description to protect morale. Trainees who are told that good technique overcomes sixty-two pupils will discover otherwise in their first term and will then distrust everything else the course told them. The unit's own answer is better: the conditions are real, some of them are not yours to fix, and there is still a short honest list of what is.

Sequencing across the two-week block

Four topics over two weeks: 5.1 and 5.2 in Week 12, 5.3 and 5.4 in Week 13.

Topic 5.1 is the longest in the course and carries five sub-topics. Give it two sessions if you can, splitting after burnout and before the multilingual and multi-grade material.

The misconceptions that recur

"Burnout is just being very tired." Correct this early and precisely, because the three dimensions do real work later. The most useful moment is the

cynicism point: ask the class whether they have met a teacher who advised them not to bother with a weak class, and let them reinterpret that memory.

"The home language is the problem." In some cohorts this is a firmly held position with institutional backing, and trainees may have been taught it. Argue it on cognitive load rather than on rights, at least first; the rights argument lands better once the practical one is accepted.

"Integrating technology means using it in every lesson." Trainees who have seen technology used as display will recognise the correction quickly.

"A teacher's status is fixed and nothing I do affects it." The status and recognition distinction is the repair. Do not let it collapse into "be respected instead of paid properly", which is a different and much worse claim.

"The answer to difficult conditions is resilience." The most important of the five, and the one most likely to be reinforced elsewhere in a trainee's experience. Topic 5.4 names it directly.

Handling what this unit surfaces about the profession

Two predictable moments.

Some trainees will say they chose teaching because nothing else was available. Topic 3.2 said this is common and should not be met with exhortation. In this unit it may surface more sharply, because the conditions are being described honestly for the first time. The useful response is that attitude is a stance rather than a feeling, and that this unit's final topic is about what remains available regardless of how anyone arrived.

Some trainees will be angry, and the anger is frequently justified. Do not manage it away. Direct it: Unit 1's professional associations and Topic 5.4's second region, what you can influence, are where collective pressure belongs, and a cohort that leaves knowing the difference between what to endure, what to change and what to organise about has understood the unit.

Practical work

Shadow and itemise (Week 12). The Topic 5.1 task. Reliable and often the most affecting thing in the unit: trainees consistently find that uncounted work exceeds timetabled work. Ask for the ratio rather than the detail in the debrief, and collect the ratios on the board. The distribution makes the point better than any individual account.

Brief trainees that this is not an audit of their host teacher. The framing is "what does this job actually consist of", and a trainee who presents it otherwise will damage a placement.

Three people, one question (Week 12). The Topic 5.2 task. If parent access is difficult in your setting, two respondents are enough; do not let the task be dropped because the third is unavailable.

Judge one technology use (Week 13). The Topic 5.3 task. Many practicum schools will have almost no technology, and "there is none" is a legitimate finding. Redirect those trainees to a photocopied internet resource, which every school has and which raises the accuracy and alignment question.

Place it and change it (Week 13). The Topic 5.4 task, and the one to protect if time is short. Require the change to be makeable without permission, and check that requirement when you read the half-pages. The commonest failure is a plan that depends on the head agreeing to something.

Marking the unit assessment

The bank is on the unit assessment page with model answers and analytic rubrics.

ERQ 5 is the integrative item, and its Diagnosis criterion is deliberately the hardest thing in the bank. The remark about group work admits two defensible readings, and the unit teaches both: Topic 5.1's cynicism dimension, and Topic 5.4's accurate judgement about the third region being used to excuse inaction in the first. Mr Bilal is the worked case of the second, and topic-04 says plainly that he "is not wrong about the numbers".

Do not award the Strong band for naming cynicism alone, and do not withhold it from a candidate who argues for the Topic 5.4 reading.

Award it for distinguishing the two and arguing from the text which the evidence supports. Telling an exhausted judgement apart from an accurate one is the discrimination this unit exists to teach; a candidate who reaches for the first label is doing to the described teacher exactly what the unit warns against.

Two marking cautions specific to this unit. First, RRQ 2 asks where each burnout source was conducted; that is deliberate, and a candidate who cites the studies without their scope should lose the mark, because this unit is partly about citation discipline. Second, ERQ 4 and ERQ 5 both invite an answer that is really a complaint about the system. A complaint may be accurate and it is not an answer; the rubrics cap it.

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

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